

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

buy. If you just wander up and down the aisles picking and choosing what you WANT, you will certainly overspend and still not get what you NEED. The degree to which you stick to a predetermined list will decide how far your money goes.

I read a study several years ago that dealt with grocery store marketing, specifically what and why people buy in a grocery store. It was well established that women are the primary food shoppers, although many more men are now shopping as two-income families grow. Grocery stores love for men to shop because they buy an average of 10-12 percent more and tend to buy more expensive items.

The survey demonstrated that most shoppers have predetermined routes they take through the aisles and most tend to buy more when the shopping cart is empty. The science of shelf layout was duly noted. Shoppers will be attracted to the items that are within easy reach. So most “junk” foods are placed at eye level, if possible. Staple products such as salt, flour, rice, and sugar can be stocked virtually anywhere if they are clearly identified, and most shoppers will find them because they need those items.

Most shoppers take from one to three seconds to select the brands they want, so name recognition is vital to sales. Hence, all the advertising dollars spent are not really wasted, especially on kid’s cereals. It’s amazing that mothers who wouldn’t think about spoon-feeding raw sugar to their children quite effectively do the same thing through many of the foods they buy.

Personally, we keep our grocery money in an envelope and buy only on a cash basis. A good shopping list is made by deciding what meals you will have between pay periods, checking the shelves at home to see what you already have, and making a list of what you’re missing. The best way to stick to your list is to leave your husband at home. We’re junk-food shoppers and tend to splurge on foods. Also, avoid prepared foods like TV dinners. They’re normally 40-50 percent more expensive.

One method that many families have found to reduce their